Committee, more than a decade after the company was dead and buried, when its president pointedly asked S.D. Krishna Aiyangar if the ships were modern ones, he parried the question with the words, 'They were quite fit for the service which they were intended.'[158] While the president did not take him up on this, Scindia's Lalubhai Samaldas, who could be expected to be sympathetic to the Swadeshi company, persisted with this line of questioning. To his query, if the vessels were too old, Krishna Aiyangar replied that 'One of them was new; the other was about 10 years old' but reasserted that 'it was quite fit for the service'.[159]

At this distance in time and the scanty documentation available, it is impossible to judge if there had been a mistake. Acquiring a steamer could not have been easy in the best of times. If the company bungled—due to lack of experience accentuated by the hostile atmosphere—it was quite understandable.



With the *Gallia* practically grounded, another steamer and a launch were needed. Though the *Lawoe* had made twenty-seven voyages carrying nearly 2,000 passengers,[160] it too was not in the best condition.

Even in April, there was talk of buying another steamer, and thus increasing the daily revenue from Rs 700 to Rs 2,000.[161] As a stopgap arrangement SSNCo chartered the *Ipswich* from Shah Line Company though no money had been advanced.[162] Why the relationship with Shah Line Company was renewed after the earlier bad blood is not clear. This time around it proved to be an even worse arrangement.[163] 'They have been badly "sold" over the steamer' reported the district superintendent of police. Further, the company was being bled by the ship's officers over coal.[164] 'The *Ipswich* of the Shah Line Company, chartered by our company,' conceded SSNCo's annual report for 1908–09, 'turned out to be a virtually unseaworthy vessel and a very considerable portion of our loss was due to the charter of this vessel for six months. It was impossible for the managing body to rescind the contract though they came to know that the vessel was